Week 1

JOURNEY

JOURNEY: ADVOCATES® · LEADER HANDOUT · UNIT 1 · LESSON 1

Apologetics

BIG IDEA

Apologetics comes from the Greek apologia in 1 Peter 3:15: giving a reasoned defense for the hope we have, with gentleness and respect. This year asks students, and you, to know why you believe what you believe and to discuss it intelligently.

Key points from the Leader Video

1. Peter commands believers to be prepared to give a reason, a courtroom-style defense, for their faith; that word apologia is where apologetics comes from.
2. Peter wrote to Christians persecuted by Rome, and that same responsibility to stand and defend belief applies to us today.
3. Being called to give a defense also means being capable of one; Peter in Acts 4:20 could not stop speaking of what he had seen and heard.
4. Some cite 1 Corinthians 2 to claim persuasion is dangerous, but in context Paul is not forbidding reasoned evidence; Jesus, Paul, and Peter all gave good reasons.
5. Create an environment where students can ask anything, even questions that voice doubt, and feel safe doing it.
6. You do not need every answer; saying 'let's figure this out together' builds the relationship and finds the answer, using church, seminary, and Awana resources.

SCRIPTURE IN THE VIDEO 1 Peter 3:15 · Acts 4:20 · 1 Corinthians 2

FOR YOU

Before club: think it through yourself.

1. Why do you believe what you believe, and can you discuss those beliefs intelligently?
2. Do your students feel free to ask any question, including ones that voice doubt? What would make it safer?
3. How will you respond when a student asks something you cannot answer?
4. What resources or people could you draw on this year when hard questions come up?

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WEEK 1 · LEADER VIDEO

The full transcript

The talk from this week's Leader Video, lightly edited for reading. Times point back to that moment in the video.

The foundational verse

0:06 In 1 Peter 3:15, Peter wrote this: "But in your hearts, set apart Christ as Lord. Always be prepared to give an answer to everyone who asks you, to give a reason for the hope that you have. But do this with gentleness and respect." Oftentimes, when we're talking about things like apologetics, this verse is the foundational verse that everyone seems to cite. Why? Well, because it is in this verse that we get the idea of apologetics.

0:39 So Peter is asking us, or commanding us, to give a reason. He's saying, give an actual reason. Well, what does it mean to give a reason? In this context, it means to give a defense: to give some kind of defending idea about what you believe. This is actually the Greek word apologia, and that's where we get the idea of apologetics. It literally comes from the word apology. Now, we're not talking about apologizing for what I believe.

1:16 But imagine for a moment a courtroom scenario, where you were on the stand and you had to give a defense — you had to give a reason for your actions, a reason for what you believe, or a reason just for what you're doing. In the ancient world, the context that Peter is talking about here is a group of Christians who were being persecuted by the Roman government. Here, Peter is telling the believers to be prepared, to know why you believe what you believe, to be able to stand in a formal sense in this context and give a reason, give a defense, defend one's belief in something.

1:53 And we take this command that Peter gives the early Christians and we say, you know what, we have the exact same responsibility in our day. It's to be able to stand when the questions come and to be able to give a reason for what we believe and why we believe it. So essentially, this is what apologetics is, and this is what you and your students are going to embark on this coming year.

Called and capable

2:18 But it's more than just making a defense. It's the idea that we are both called, but we're also called to be capable. See, it's more than just saying, "I have to give a defense." How are you going to give a defense? What do you know, that would let you stand there and tell somebody what you believe and why? So this is exactly what we start to see — and what your students are going to start to see — with Peter in the early stages of Acts.

2:48 If you look at what Peter says in Acts, we've got this guy who literally ran away at the crucifixion, but then all of a sudden, in Acts, is proclaiming what he has seen and heard. We see in Acts 4:20 Peter say, "We can do nothing but speak of the things that we have seen and heard." So there was just this massive, compelling nature in them to be able to speak about the things they had seen and heard.

Is apologetics necessary?

3:16 Now, it is important to remember that some people might not really think that this idea of apologetics is all that necessary. In fact, some might even say it's dangerous, and they might even look to passages like 1 Corinthians chapter 2, where Paul gives this idea that it is not by human wisdom or human power that he comes to the Corinthian church — that he didn't come with wise and persuasive words. A lot of people will take this to mean that we don't argue and that we don't want to persuade people. But in context, that's not exactly what Paul is talking about.

3:57 So we are called to maturity. We're called to be able to give evidence. We'll see throughout this study that if you look at the life of Jesus, if you look at the life of Paul, if you look at the things that Peter did, all of them gave consistent and good reasons for what they believed and why they believed it. So what we're really asking students, right out of the gate here, is to consider that very question: Why do you believe what you believe, and can you discuss those beliefs intelligently? Why do you believe what you believe?

4:31 So you and your students are headed on a huge, huge journey here, and it starts with getting students to begin thinking about these kinds of spiritual conversations. Some of the material we're going to be talking about is pretty heavy. Some of the topics we're going to be dealing with are going to be very challenging, not only for you, but challenging for your students as well. So you want to create a certain kind of environment.

Create a safe environment

4:58 Now, some of you may already have this environment in your groups and some of you may not, but I want to encourage you to create an environment that really fosters this key idea of being able to ask and answer questions. This might seem really, really simple — "Well, yes, of course my students can ask questions" — but you would be surprised at the number of students who just don't feel like they can ask any question. Not just the difficult question, but maybe the question that really questions their own faith, the question that invites in this idea of doubt.

5:36 Now, we're going to be dealing with doubt, but much later. So you have to be able to create an environment where your students feel like they can ask anything, where they feel welcome, where it's a safe place. But that doesn't mean that you have to have all of the answers, because let's be honest: you're not going to have all the answers. Your students ask great questions.

5:59 In all the years that I've been a Christian educator, I have seen some amazing questions — the kind that leave you standing there with your jaw dropped. I don't know what to say to that, because I never would have thought of that question, and I love those kinds of questions. Don't feel like you have to have all the answers.

6:18 But what goes even further than having all of the answers is being able to walk alongside a student and say, "Hey, listen, I don't know the answer, but let's you and me figure this out together." That's going to do exactly what our goal is. That's going to create a stronger

relationship between you and your students, while at the same time figuring out the answer to their question.

Resources to lean on

6:42 So use the resources that you have available to you inside your church. Possibly a school or a seminary that might be nearby. Friends and family of yours who may have a deeper understanding. But also use us. We're here at AwanaYM.org. We have a ton of resources and a library that we are continuing to build. Definitely check out Sean's website at SeanMcDowell.org — he's got a ton of resources. And if you are still stumped, you can even contact us directly, and we are happy to help you in any way that we can.

7:18 We are here to assist you in this journey, but I can't stress this enough: be sure that your small group leaders — and you, in terms of a large group, whatever it is that you have going on — make sure your students feel like they can do this, that they can ask anything. And it might start with you giving them some of the questions that even you have, in terms of figuring out what this looks like. So get ready, dive in, don't hold back.

7:49 And know that all of us here at the Home Office are praying for you, praying for each other and for other groups around the country that are on this journey with you, as we navigate together what this looks like, as we explore more deeply what it means to be believers in Christ — what that looks like, how do we defend it, and how do we guide our students so that when they graduate, when they move on to bigger and better things beyond your youth group, they are prepared to successfully engage their culture and further the Kingdom of God.